GROUP 7

THE SONG OF ROLAND: SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The Song of Roland is an Old French epic poem (*chanson de geste*, "song of deeds") of about 4,000 lines. It is the oldest surviving major work of French literature. It tells of the last stand of Roland, nephew of Charlemagne, at the Battle of Roncevaux Pass, and of the revenge that followed [1, 3].

1. Historical and Cultural Background

What actually happened

Why Charlemagne went to Spain. In 777, Muslim Spain (al-Andalus) was divided. Several local Muslim governors in the north-east, led by Sulayman al-Arabi of Barcelona, were rebelling against Abd al-Rahman I, the Umayyad emir of Córdoba. They travelled to Charlemagne's court at Paderborn (in present-day Germany) and offered him their cities, including Zaragoza, in return for military help. Charlemagne saw a chance to extend both his kingdom and Christendom south of the Pyrenees [11].

What went wrong? In 778 the Frankish army crossed the Pyrenees, but the plan fell apart. Husayn, governor of Zaragoza, refused to open the gates, saying he had never promised loyalty to Charlemagne. After a siege of over a month, the Franks accepted gold and prisoners and withdrew [11]. Trouble back home (a Saxon uprising near the Rhine) also pulled Charlemagne north [12].

Where and how Roland died. On the way back, Charlemagne tore down the walls of Pamplona, the main town of the Christian Basques of Navarre, and harshly treated the region [2, 11]. On the evening of **15 August 778**, as the army crossed the narrow mountain **Pass of Roncevaux (Roncesvalles)** in the western Pyrenees, between modern Spain and France, Basque mountaineers ambushed the rearguard and baggage train. Using their knowledge of the terrain and their light weapons, they killed every man and looted the baggage, probably including the gold from Zaragoza [2, 11]. Charlemagne's biographer Einhard names three of the dead: Eggihard, the royal steward; Anselm, the count palatine; and **Roland, prefect of the Breton March** [2, 11]. The real Roland was therefore a minor frontier commander, killed by Christians, not Muslims, in a failed campaign.

How history became legend

For three centuries, minstrels (*jongleurs*) retold the defeat in song, and with each retelling it grew. By the time the poem took its surviving form (c. 1040–1115), Europe was absorbed in the *Reconquista* against Muslim Spain and the First Crusade (1095–1099). The poem therefore changes the Basque raiders into a vast Saracen army, turns Roland into Charlemagne's nephew and greatest knight, and presents Charlemagne, already legendary, as a 200-year-old champion of Christendom [1, 3, 6]. The best surviving copy is an Anglo-Norman manuscript of the 12th century kept at the Bodleian Library, Oxford [11]. The result was less a history than a model of knighthood: a story meant to inspire courage, loyalty, and holy war [1].

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2. Characters and Setting

Characters

Character	Role	Description
Roland	*Protagonist · Tragic Hero*	Charlemagne's nephew and greatest knight, bearer of the sword Durendal and the horn Olifant. Fearless and loyal, but his excessive pride (*desmesure*) leads to disaster [4, 6].
Oliver	*Deuteragonist · Foil to Roland*	Roland's best friend and future brother-in-law. Wise and prudent; his advice would likely have saved the rearguard [6].
Charlemagne	*Heroic King · Avenger*	Emperor of the Franks, shown as a white-bearded, 200-year-old ruler guided by God through dreams and the angel Gabriel [5, 6].
Ganelon	*Main Antagonist · Traitor*	Roland's stepfather, a respected baron. Wounded pride turns into revenge, and revenge into treason [5].
Archbishop Turpin	*Supporting Hero · Warrior-Priest*	Fights beside Roland and blesses the dying; joins faith and arms (*militia Christi*) [6].
King Marsile	*Antagonist · Enemy King*	Saracen ruler of Saragossa who accepts Ganelon's plot; loses his right hand to Roland and later dies of grief [5, 6].
Blancandrin	*Secondary Antagonist · Schemer*	Marsile's wisest counselor. He invents the false peace offer and, riding with Ganelon, helps plan the ambush [4, 5].
Baligant	*Final Antagonist · Charlemagne's Foil*	Emir of Babylon and Marsile's overlord. He arrives with a vast army after Roncevaux and is Charlemagne's pagan mirror-image; he is slain by Charlemagne in single combat [4, 6].
Duke Naimes	*Supporting Character · Wise Counselor*	Charlemagne's trusted adviser; first to recognize that Roland's horn signals battle [6].
Aude	*Minor Character · Tragic Figure*	Oliver's sister and Roland's betrothed, who dies of grief on hearing of his death [6].
Thierry and Pinabel	*Minor Characters · Champions at the Trial*	Thierry defends Charlemagne's cause; Pinabel defends Ganelon. Their duel decides Ganelon's fate [6].

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Setting

Time. The story is set in the late 8th century, during the reign of Charlemagne, after seven years of Frankish war in Spain, and is based on a real battle of 15 August 778. Because the poem was composed about three centuries later, its world of knights, feudal oaths, and holy war reflects 11th-century, Crusade-era France more than Charlemagne's own time [1, 3].

Place. The action moves through three main locations:

- **Saragossa (Zaragoza), Spain:** King Marsile's city and the last Saracen stronghold, where the false peace and Ganelon's betrayal are planned, and where Baligant later lands his army [4].
- **The Pass of Roncevaux (Roncesvalles):** a narrow pass in the Pyrenees between Spain and France, in present-day Navarre, about 1,177 metres above sea level. The rearguard is ambushed here, and its steep valleys and hills shape the story: Oliver spots the enemy from a hilltop, and the horn must carry across the mountains [2].
- **Aix (Aix-la-Chapelle / Aachen):** Charlemagne's capital, where Aude dies of grief and Ganelon is tried [4].

Atmosphere. A feudal, Christian world at war, sharply divided between Christian Franks and "pagan" Saracens. God intervenes openly through dreams, the angel Gabriel, and even by holding the sun still, reflecting how 11th-century Europe viewed its struggle with Muslim Spain [1].

3. The Story

Retold in short-story form from the poem [4, 10].

I. The False Peace

For seven years Charlemagne had waged war in Spain, and every city had fallen except Saragossa. Inside its walls, King Marsile called his council in despair. The wise Blancandrin spoke: send Charlemagne rich gifts, lions, bears, camels, hawks, and mules laden with gold, along with hostages of noble birth. Promise that Marsile will follow him to France and be baptized a Christian. Once the Franks have gone home, the promise can be broken. The hostages may lose their heads, Blancandrin admitted, but better that than losing Spain.
At Charlemagne's camp, the barons argued. Young Roland wanted no peace: Marsile had once beheaded two Frankish envoys, and he would lie again. But Ganelon, a proud baron and Roland's stepfather, called this reckless, and old Duke Naimes agreed that a beaten enemy asking for mercy should be heard. The emperor chose peace. Then came the question of who would carry the reply into the enemy city. Roland named his stepfather. Ganelon, white with anger, saw it as a death sentence and swore before all the court that he would have his revenge.

II. The Traitor's Bargain

On the road to Saragossa, Ganelon rode beside Blancandrin, and the two men found they

hated the same person. As long as Roland lived, said Ganelon, Charlemagne would never stop making war. Before Marsile, Ganelon first played the bold envoy, so insulting that the king hurled a spear at him, then quietly sold out his own people. The plan was simple: Ganelon would see that Roland commanded the rearguard on the march home, and Marsile would fall on it with his whole army. Ganelon returned with gold, the keys of the city, and the lie that the treaty was sealed.

That night Charlemagne dreamed of his spear shattered in Ganelon's hands. Still, when Ganelon proposed Roland for the rearguard, Roland would not refuse a post of honor. He stayed behind with Oliver, Archbishop Turpin, the Twelve Peers, and 20,000 men, while the emperor marched toward France with tears in his eyes.

III. The Horn That Was Not Blown

From a hill above Roncevaux, Oliver saw the valleys fill with glittering helmets: a Saracen army of hundreds of thousands. Three times he begged Roland to sound the Olifant and call Charlemagne back. Three times Roland refused. To call for help, he said, would shame him and all of France. "Roland is fierce and Oliver is wise," the poet remarks. Turpin blessed the troops and promised Paradise to any who fell, and the battle began.

The Franks fought like heroes. Roland's sword Durendal and Oliver's Hauteclaire cut down champion after champion, and Roland struck off Marsile's right hand. But for every Saracen killed, more arrived, and one by one the Peers fell. When only a handful remained, Roland at last wanted to blow the horn. Now Oliver turned on him: it was too late, and Roland's pride had killed them all. Turpin ended the quarrel. The horn could no longer save them, he said, but it could bring the emperor back to avenge and bury them.

IV. The Death of Roland

Roland blew the Olifant so hard that blood burst from his mouth and his temples split. Thirty leagues away, Charlemagne heard it. Ganelon scoffed that Roland was only hunting, but Naimes knew better, and the emperor had the traitor seized and turned his army back.

At Roncevaux, Oliver, blinded by his own blood, struck Roland by mistake; the two friends forgave each other, and Oliver died. Turpin died blessing the bodies of the fallen. Alone, Roland tried to shatter Durendal on a rock so no pagan would ever hold it, but the blade would not break. He lay down under a pine tree, his face toward Spain so all would know he died a conqueror, confessed his sins, and raised his right glove to God. The angel Gabriel took it, and angels carried Roland's soul to Paradise.

V. Vengeance and Judgment

Charlemagne arrived to find a field of dead. God held the sun still so he could chase the fleeing Saracens, and many drowned in the river Ebro. Then a new enemy appeared: Baligant, the aged Emir of Babylon, whom Marsile had called for help years before, landed with an army gathered from every pagan land. The two old rulers met in single combat. Baligant split Charlemagne's helmet, but at the voice of Gabriel the emperor struck back and killed him. Saragossa fell, Marsile died of grief, and his queen, Bramimonde, was taken to France to become a Christian. At Aix, Roland's betrothed Aude heard the news and fell dead at the emperor's feet. Ganelon was put on trial. He argued that he had taken revenge on Roland in

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the open, which was no treason. Afraid of his kinsman Pinabel, the barons wavered, until the knight Thierry offered to prove Ganelon's guilt by combat. Thierry won. Ganelon was torn apart by four horses, and thirty of his kinsmen were hanged. That night, Gabriel called Charlemagne to yet another war, and the weary emperor wept: "God, how hard my life is!"

4. Central Conflict

- The story revolves around several conflicts; the overarching external conflict is a religious and territorial war between Christian Franks and Muslim Saracens, painted in stark terms of good versus evil. Aside from this, the choices of the characters, such as how Ganelon placed a private grudge above his oath to his king and country, show a conflict of loyalty against treason. Lastly, Roland's sense of honor clashes with Oliver's practical wisdom, and 20,000 men pay the price; their choices show a conflict between pride and prudence.

5. Dominant Themes

- Being literature in the medieval ages, The Song of Roland exhibits themes that are dominant in those times, inspired by the current social and religious systems.
    - **Feudal loyalty and betrayal:** society rests on sworn bonds between lord and vassal; breaking them is the worst crime.
    - **Holy war and martyrdom:** death in battle for the faith earns paradise, which turns Roland's defeat into a victory.
    - **Pride and its cost:** courage without judgment destroys the very people a leader is meant to protect.
    - **Divine justice:** God sides openly with the Franks through dreams, miracles, and the outcome of trial by combat.

6. Values Reflected

- Because of the characters being knights and warriors who fought for conquest and religion, the values reflected in the story are aligned to loyalty and faith, mainly:
    - **Chivalry:** courage, martial skill, and honor in battle.
    - **Vassalage:** faithful service to one's lord and to God.
    - **Brotherhood:** deep loyalty between companions-in-arms, seen in Roland and Oliver.

7. Relevance to Contemporary Issues

- The real story behind The Song of Roland is that of propaganda against the Muslims, hubris of leaders, and betrayals. To be more specific:
    - **Polarization and propaganda:** the poem turned a Christian enemy into a Muslim one to suit its time, a reminder of how stories can manufacture "us vs. them" hostility.

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- **Crisis leadership and hubris:** a leader who will not ask for help to protect his image endangers everyone.
- **Betrayal and institutional loyalty:** Ganelon's defense, that revenge is not treason, raises questions about personal grievances versus public duty.

8. Connections to Bikol Culture

- **Epic tradition:** the Bikol epic *Ibalong* likewise celebrates heroes, Baltog, Handiong, and Bantong, who defeat monsters to bring peace and order to the land [7, 8].
- **Communal loyalty:** feudal loyalty parallels Bikolano *pakikisama*, *utang na loob*, and respect for community leaders.
- **Faith:** the knights' Christian devotion echoes Bikol's devotion to Our Lady of Peñafrancia (*Ina*), a unifying pillar of the region [9].
- **Oral tradition:** like the minstrel-sung *chanson*, the *Ibalong* was passed on orally by a bard (Kadunung) before being written down [7, 8].

9. Sustainability of Literature

- **Cultural memory:** the poem preserves a people's identity and values across generations.
- **Adaptation:** it survived by moving from oral song to manuscript, print, translation, and classroom study.
- **Universality:** it endures not for historical accuracy but for its human conflicts: pride, friendship, sacrifice, and grief.

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